investors could be found mostly in the metros," he says.

Digital connectivity has been another enabler, breaching barriers of time and distance. A report published by the Internet and Mobile Association of India this July put the number of active internet users in India at 692 million, of which 351 million are in rural India. The number is expected to go up to 900 million by 2025. As many as 346 million Indians are engaged in online transactions, including e-commerce and digital payments, a higher number than the 331 million people engaged in digital transactions in the US. It's a metric that is helping not just start-up enterprises in small towns but also conventional ones to reach newer markets in a swift and cost-effective manner. This has fed the burst of entrepreneurial activity in the country, reflected in data from the corporate affairs ministry, which recorded the number of registered companies in India in 2021-22 at 167,076, a 7.5 per cent increase over the previous year.

The curse of the Covid-19 pandemic proved to be a boon for the expansion of digital infrastructure in the country, connecting factories with the end market seamlessly. And as the small towns and cities grew and connectivity improved, so did the quality of life for their people, be it in terms of health or education infrastructure, or in avenues of entertainment. "There is a lot of enterprise that is booming all across the country," says Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda. "Doing the same thing in metros is an expensive proposition. In smaller towns, the infrastructure tends to be better. Firms are also able to hire local talent that comes cheap." Property, too, is relatively cheaper in Tier II or even smaller cities. For instance, the average price of property in Nagpur, as per Housing.com, is Rs 4,401 per square feet com-

THE ALCHEMIST

KAMAL KISHORE SARDA, 70
Raipur, Chhattisgarh

Company
Sarda Energy and Minerals Ltd

Net Worth
Rs 1,400 crore



RAJWANT RAWAT

A gold medallist from the National Institute of Technology (NIT), Nagpur, where he studied mechanical engineering in 1974, Kamal Sarda began his career working at the family-owned rolling mill in Nagpur. Four years later, when his mentor Fakirchand Tejpal made him an offer to buy his steel plant, The Raipur Alloys and Steel Ltd, at Bhanpuri, Sarda obliged, taking it over along with its 350 employees.

Alloy steel, the product manufactured at the plant, did well till the 1990s, when a combination of domestic and international factors hit the sector badly. Within a few years, the plant faced closure, which is when Sarda, the visionary that he was, fell back on another sector that he had predicted would do well—mining. The businessman had applied for leases to coal mines in Chhattisgarh to secure raw material.

When the Maharashtra energy department put three power plants at Khaparkheda on the block, the Sardas bought them. Two of these were later sold to run the third. Commissioned in 2001, it marked the Sardas' foray into the energy sector. Meanwhile, when Ajit Jogi became chief minister of newly-formed Chhattisgarh in 2000, he asked Sarda to prepare a report on how to revive the steel sector. His recommendations saw the sector beginning to show signs of recovery. The group then set up a ferro alloy plant at Siltara, Raipur, to utilise a power plant they had installed earlier. In 2012-13, they set up another ferro alloy plant in Visakhapatnam.

With green energy becoming a buzzword across the world, the Sardas see a future in hydro power. They have commissioned a 113 MW hydel project in Sikkim, a 25 MW plant in Chhattisgarh, and a third in Uttarakhand.

The group has also extended its footprint to dairy and agro, setting up a state-of-the-art modern dairy with 2,000 cows at Kharora in Chhattisgarh in 2014. They are also exploring vegetable seed production, engaging 40 scientists for R&D. Currently, the group has investments in Chhattisgarh, MP, Uttarakhand, Sikkim, Andhra Pradesh and Indonesia, with an employee base of around 20,000.

-Rahul Noronha